

ALL SHAPES AND SIZES

Sharks have lived in the world's oceans for more than 400 million years. Today, there are more than 470 different species. Many are fast, streamlined open-water hunters, but other sharks have strange adaptations that equip them for life on the seabed, or in the dark, cold depths of the deep ocean.



▲ SAW SHARK

An effective weapon, the swordlike snout of this shark is edged with razor-sharp teeth.



▲ THRESHER SHARK

The upper lobe of the thresher's tail is as long as its body. It uses it like a whip to stun its prey.



▲ WOBLEGONG

This ambush killer lies on the seabed, relying on its camouflage to hide from its prey.



▲ FRILLED SHARK

The eel-like frilled shark is a living fossil, resembling the earliest ancestors of all sharks.

Sharks

The most notorious oceanic hunters are the predatory sharks with their terrifyingly sharp teeth. In fact, not all sharks are like this. Some are lazy shellfish feeders, and others eat only very small animals. But many are powerful killers that combine lethal teeth with acute senses and amazing speed. They have few enemies aside from other, bigger sharks.

Crescent-shaped tail fin is adapted for speed

Tall triangular dorsal fin helps keep the shark upright as it swims

Powerful streamlined body

WOW!

A great white shark has 300 teeth, and since they are always being replaced, it may get through 30,000 teeth in its lifetime.

▲ GREAT WHITE SHARK

The massively powerful great white reaches lengths of up to 23 ft (7 m). It is found in all tropical and temperate oceans, mainly near coasts.